

Marco A. Carenza

Karina Popp

Game Studies

3 March 2026

The Game Known as Cooking

The activity of cooking predates civilization as we know it. Over 800,000 years ago our ancestors would cook food because it was easier to eat and digest.¹ In the modern age we tend to ignore that fact, instead we focus on the tastes and appearances of our food. Cooking is one of the most celebrated cultural artifacts, they show-off insights into cultures, as people from all around the world love sharing their recipes and indulging in foreign traditional meals. For a lot of people cooking is a game, the higher someone's skill the more game-like it can become. My argument is that cooking is a game because the chefs (not professional cooks, just the person who is cooking) must enter the magic circle (see Johan Huizinga's *Homo Ludens*) in order to make their meals, it falls in line with Roger Caillois' definition of play, as well as belonging to Caillois' category of play, specifically mimicry (see Roger Caillois's *Man, Play and Games*)

To introduce my first point I will define what the magic circle is. According to Huizinga, "The magic circle ... [and other "play-grounds"] are temporary worlds within the ordinary world, dedicated to the performance of an act.", meaning that any game creates a "play-ground" where the participants dismiss the common world so that they can commit themselves to an activity. In cooking the chefs must separate themselves from the chaos of the common world and find a space where they can "play" in peace, no matter the skill levels. Even street food vendors, the chefs who arguably are the most present in the common world, still require their magic circle (a cart or some kind of surface) to cook. Additionally, Huizinga goes on to describe that the

¹ See: <https://askanexpert.asu.edu/anthropology/first-cooks>

magic circle takes the participants into “an imperfect world and into the confusion of life it brings a temporary, a limited perfection. ... The least deviation from it "spoils the game", robs it of its character and makes it worthless.” The quote describing the sanctuary that the magic circle creates for its players, with any action that causes the players to depart from it will “spoil the game and make it worthless”. While I do not fully agree that deviations make the act of cooking worthless, I do agree with the fact that the magic circle needs to be maintained in order to successfully cook something. Anyone who has cooked knows that there can be too many chefs in the kitchen, and even if they are trying to help, these other chefs can be a nuisance and spoil the experience, leading to a poor cooking experience resulting in a poorly made meal.

My second point to cooking being a game comes with it fitting Caillois’ definition of what a play is. According to Caillois play must be: Free (playing is not obligatory), Separate (contained within a space and time), Uncertain (the results cannot be fully determined beforehand), Unproductive (not create new goods or wealth, except for exchange of property ending in a situation identical to the start of the game), Governed by rules (which suspend ordinary laws) and Make-believe (creating awareness of a second reality that isn’t real life). Cooking is Free because the chefs who are participating in it must be willing to do it. Cooking is an involved activity, forcing someone to cook will make them miserable and will therefore not properly engage in it. People who don’t want to cook will turn to alternatives, they will make the simplest recipes and not get creative or even just not cook at all and eat something premade for them. Cooking is Separate as its players will explicitly make time for what they want to cook, setting an amount of time proportional to the dish's complexity. Cooking is Uncertain because the outcome of a session is never truly determined. Typically the higher a chef’s skill the more likely the dish will be well made, however, even professionals can make simple mistakes as

human error is always possible. Cooking is Unproductive, it falls under the exception of property exchange. A chef exchanges their raw ingredients with cooked ones, there is no new amount being created. [this is a stretch so idk] Cooking is Governed by rules, through experience chefs learn to follow standards which are unique to the act of cooking alone such as Mise en Place, or to Cook by Temperature, Not by Time (see McChesney-Wachs *Top 10 cooking rules.*)² Cooking is Make-believe, as chefs create an imaginary world where they are in control of everything, making all the decisions, shouldering the work in order to overcome the odds of making the dish.

My final point is that Cooking is a game that falls under Caillois' classification of games, the categories being Mimicry and Agon. Mimicry is defined as games in which a player can mimic or roleplay another player of a game. An example would be playing sports, where casual players pretend to mimic the professional athletes they see on television. Cooking is like playing sports in this example, there are cases where spectators see chefs on their television in cooking competitions or shows, and when they go to their own kitchen they enter their own magic circle and try their best to mimic these professionals. Agon is defined as games that are competitions, each player shows off their superiority in a given area where it can be recognized. Examples are once again sports, any sport competition or even the Olympics. Cooking falls into this category as they have their own competitions, like Master Chef, where chefs from all over the world compete to prove who is the best in the kitchen.

After examining Huizinga's magic circle, Caillois' definition of play, and Caillois' categories of play, cooking can be seen as a game. Chefs must enter a magic circle in order to perform their act, it fully aligns with all six of Caillois' definition of play points, while also demonstrating that it falls under both Agon and Mimicry depending on a chef's skill.

² <https://saltpepperskillet.com/cooking-rules/>

Notes

Works Cited